

Department of English and Film Studies
ENGL 569 A1: Ethical Listening
Fall Term 2022

Instructor: Michael O'Driscoll

Contact: mo@ualberta.ca

Office Hours: Zoom: Wednesday 10:00-11:00am. In Person: Thursdays 1:00-2:00pm.

Office: HC 3-47 / Zoom Room: <https://us02web.zoom.us/j/6354152761>

Class Schedule: Tuesdays 10:00am-1:00pm; HC 2-17

Territorial Acknowledgement:

The University of Alberta acknowledges that we are located on Treaty 6 territory and Métis Nation Homeland, and respects the histories, languages, and cultures of First Nations, Métis, Inuit, and all First Peoples of Canada, whose presence continues to enrich our vibrant community. To learn more about the traditional territories near and far, visit [Native Land Digital](#).

Course Description:

This graduate seminar will focus on the ethics of listening as the theoretical province of literary, cultural, sound, and philosophical studies while also attending to the operations of listening in contemporary culture and in the seminar room. We'll explore a pedagogy of attunement through innovative listening exercises and exploratory field work, and we'll listen in on various creative works (literary performance, theoretical argument, and otherwise) that enact, produce, and thematize listening practices. In her book *The Other Side of Language*, philosopher Gemma Corradi Fiumara remarks that genuine listening "creates ever new spaces in the very 'place' it is carried out," while for philosopher Lisbeth Lipari, an "ethics of attunement" is an "essential form of constitutive communicative action" with "potential for social, personal, and political transformation." Certain practices of listening, these arguments contend, can be a site for the emergence of something radically new—new forms of care, new ways of relating to our environments, and new ways of relating to each other. Listening, one might say, has a powerful potential to be a revolutionary activity. At the same time, cautionary notes abound: for example, outstanding contributions to the field of Sound Studies, such as Jennifer Lynn Stoecker's *The Sonic Color Line* and Dylan Robinson's *Hungry Listening*, have foregrounded the exclusionary and extractive politics of listening. How, as Stoecker asks, have visually-driven epistemologies rendered unheard, particularly in regards to race, sound "as a repository of apprehension, oppression, and confrontation"? How, we might ask, do our listening practices efface the colonizing dynamic between what Robinson calls "the listener and the listened to"? After all, as Clint Burham has reminded us, listening is not necessarily an unalloyed "good" thing in that it constitutes the structural position occupied by the "master": listening is, after all, the traumatic economy of judges, priests, analysts... and even literary scholars.

Seminar Schedule:

Dates	Topic	Readings	Listenings
Sept 06	Introduction	No Assigned Readings	Avasilichioaei “Fellow Statements” ; Mac Low “A Vocabulary for Sharon Belle Mattlin” ; Steven Ross Smith “Two Kinds” ; Tagaq Colonizer ;
Sept 13	What is “listening”?	Nancy Listening ; Rice “Listening” ; Sterne “Hearing” ;	Cage “John Cage about silence” and 4’33” ; Oliveros “The Difference Between Hearing and Listening” ; Schafer “Listen” ;
Sept 20	Soundwalking	Loveless, “Tactical Soundwalking” ; Westerkamp “Soundwalk Practice: An Agent for Change?” ; Note: Soundwalk Planned for second half of timeslot. Guest: Ian Crutchley.	Loveless “In the Throat of Trees” ; Smallwood “Wood Buffalo National Park” ; Westerkamp “The Soundscape Speaks”
Sept 27	Deep Listening	Oliveros Deep Listening ; Steinmetz “In Recognition of Their Desperation” ;	Oliveros Deep Listening and “To Valerie Solanas and Marilyn Monroe”
Oct 04	What is “ethics”?	Levinas “Ethics and the Face” from <i>Totality and Infinity</i> ; Lipari “Listening Others to Speech”	Avasilichioaei “Operator” ; Sonuga “The Women Are Talking” ;
Oct 11	Hungry Listening	Dylan Robinson <i>Hungry Listening</i> “Introduction” , “Chapter One” ; Abel <i>Nishga</i> ;	Abel Place of Scraps and Injun ; Rogers “In The Shadow Of A Flag” and “Space Scape Home” ; Simpson “Solidification” ;
Oct 18	Listening in Place	Kit Dobson <i>Field Notes on Listening</i> ; Dianne Chisholm “My Edmonton Haunts” Note: Dobson reading this Friday October 21 @12:00pm; listening methods discussion @3:00pm.	Carpenter and Hagen “Kisiskâciwanisîpiy” ; Wong, Riddle, & Ouellet “From the Prairies to the Pacific Rim” ;
Oct 25	Listening and Race	Stoever The Sonic Color Line ; Furlonge Race Sounds ;	Baraka “Three Modes of History and Culture” ; Coleman “Skylight Books, Los Angeles, January 13, 2008” ;
Nov 01	Deafness	Mara Mills “Deafness” ; Friedner & Helmreich “Sound Studies” ; Dirksen, Bauman, and Murray “Deaf Studies”	Kim “The World is Sound” ; O’Daniel “I Felt People Dancing” (and explore her site!)
Nov 08	READING WEEK	NO SEMINAR TODAY!	Fong & O’Driscoll, Podcast: “Listening Ethically to the Spoken Word”
Nov 15	Carbon Listening	Janzen “Energy Demo(s)” ; Read background materials on “Energy Emergency Repair Kit” ; Beier et al. “A Big Pile of Glitch” ; Note: Special Guests TBA!	Beier et al. “Energy Emergency Repair Kit” and “Manifesto for Feminist Solarities” ; Janzen “Athabasca Tar Sounds”
Nov 22	Close Listening	Sterne “The Audible Past” ; Camlot “Phonopoetics” ; Bernstein “Close Listening”	Tennyson “Charge of the Light Brigade” ; Howe “Thorow” (four

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			parts) from Thieft ; Weiner Clairvoyant Journal ;
Nov 29	Listening to Noise	O’Driscoll “Collage With Jackhammer” ;	Tzara “L’admiral cherche” ; Russolo “Risveglio Di Una Citta” ; Ruttman “Wochende” ; Schaeffer “Etude aux Chemins de Fer” ; The Fugs “Swinburne Stomp” ;
Dec 6	Sound Bites	No assigned readings. No assigned listenings. Sound Bites Presentations are Due!!	

Required Texts:

There are two texts that you should acquire for reading. They can be purchased from [The Glass Bookshop](#) either online for in-person pickup or free delivery in the Edmonton area by the Glass Bookshop folks. If you mention this seminar in the comments section of your online order, you'll receive a 15% discount. Here's a nice idea: an in-person pickup might be combined with the "Field Recording & Sharing" assignment noted below.

Abel, Jordan. *Nishga*. McClelland & Stewart, 2021.

Dobson, Kit. *Field Notes on Listening*. Wolsak and Wynn, 2022.

All other required readings can be found in a Google Docs folder located [here](#). Please come prepared to our seminars having read and considered the readings assigned.

All required listenings can be found in a Google Docs folder located [here](#). Note that some are files you can stream directly, some are hyperlinked on the documented titled "Listening Resources."

Please come prepared to our seminars having read and considered the listenings assigned.

Additional useful resources that can be found through the UAlberta Library access include:

Sterne, Jonathan. Ed. *The Sound Studies Reader*. Routledge, 2012.

Novak, David and Matt Sakakeeny, Ed., *Keywords in Sound*. Duke, 2015.

Distribution of Grades

Component	Weighting	Date
Participation	10%	Full term
Listening Practice	20%	As Scheduled
Field Recording & Sharing	20%	As Scheduled
Sound Bites	20%	Dec 6
Term Paper	30%	Dec 16

Assignments

Participation (10%)

Participation is based on attendance, evident preparation for the seminar, timely completion of assigned tasks, and contributions to seminar discussions. Come to our seminar prepared by having completed the required readings and listenings. In our seminar space you are expected to be attentive, generous, and respectful.

Listening Practice (20%)

A “listening practice” is a guided, shared encounter in which the guide leads the seminar in attending to a particular sound event that they have selected for our consideration. That “sound event” can be shared through a digital audio recording (maximum 5 minutes duration) or any sounding object (eg. musical instrument, music box, typewriter, bell, etc.) of the guide’s choosing. The listening practice should be no more than 20 minutes in length and should include the following elements: 1) background information or narrative about the sound event we will experience together; 2) two or three pre-listening questions that help to us to attend in ways that will shape our listening experience and reflect on that experience; 3) the sounding of the recording or object; 4) a guided discussion following our listening experience in which the guide directs the conversation and responds to questions from other seminar members. This should be treated as an *informal* presentation. You can work from notes, but please do not prepare a script to be read. It is helpful if you can find ways to connect our guided listening experience to other issues, readings, and listenings we have shared in the seminar. Please sign up for your Listening Practice delivery date on the google doc found [here](#).

Field Recording & Sharing (20%)

This assignment invites you use your cell phone or other digital recording device to make a short recording (no longer than 5 minutes) anywhere that you like, provided that you are in a safe and permitted space that will allow you to conduct such an activity without endangering yourself or others. You might embark on a short sound walk, or you might attend to the soundscape of your home, workplace, or learning space. The purpose of this assignment is to test your own ability to attend in a focused way to an auditory environment, capture that sound for sharing, and reflect on your experience of and relationship to those sounds. As you go about your business in the coming days, attend carefully to the sound environments that you navigate. Consider possibilities that might fulfill this assignment, and think about your own positionality in relationship to the sounds you encounter. When you’ve determined which sound environment provides an opportunity for careful listening and reflection, make your recording and bring it to our seminar for sharing. Take ten minutes to contextualize and share your recording. These don’t need to be pre-scheduled—I’ll open each seminar meeting by asking if anyone has a field recording to share that day. (Note: if you do not have access to a recording device, I can provide one.)

Sound Bites (20%)

In advance of completing your term paper, you will be required to produce a short recording of no more than 4 minutes duration. The recording should include at least one short, recorded sound (in addition to your own voice) that you incorporate into your presentation as an example for analysis or an illustration of an idea. The recording should focus on a main idea or the thesis of your term paper. This is, in effect, a “sound bite” from your term paper that will help you to focus your ideas and pitch them to other seminar participants. The genre of your short recording might be an audio essay, a podcast, a radio broadcast, an interview, an audio collage—whatever you feel allows you to best represent the intentions of your term paper. In our last meeting on Tuesday, December 6th we’ll share and discuss all of the sound bites that have been produced. There is free and easy to use software that will allow you to produce this recording (Audacity and Zoom are readily available examples), and I will devote some class time to discussing best practices when it comes to sound production as well as help you to troubleshoot technological issues if need be. The point behind this is that sound production and editing are

forms of listening practice, and early users often remark that learning these skills can impact their own sense of attunement to the sound objects under consideration.

Term Paper

The term paper will be due just over one week following the last day of our seminar, or Friday, December 16th. The paper should be the length of an average conference paper, or 2500 words. (250 words typically take 2 minutes to read, hence 10 pages is the length of a standard 20 minute presentation). Write it as you were, in fact, preparing a conference presentation—in other words, as a script for voice. If you want, you can submit with it a PowerPoint presentation or any digital sound files you might include in an actual presentation. You can upload the text and supplementary files to your named folder located [here](#). I have no preconceptions about how the topics might be restricted, other than that they must bear a clear relationship to the subject matter, readings, and listenings we've encountered in this seminar. The topic should be arrived at in consultation with me, and I'm more than happy to discuss your ideas individually at any point in the term. Pro-tip: keep your eye out for any suitable, upcoming conferences and consider submitting a proposal for your paper to one of them!

Grading:

Excellent	A+	4.0	96-100
	A	4.0	91-95
	A-	3.7	86-90
Good	B+	3.3	81-85
	B	3.0	76-80
	B-	2.7	72-75
Satisfactory	C+	2.3	68-71
	C	2.0	63-67
	C-	1.7	59-62
Poor	D+	1.3	55-58
Minimal Pass	D	1.0	50-54
Fail	F	0.0	0-49

Submission Policies: In class presentations are to be delivered on the day assigned. The Listening Practice schedule and Sound Bites session are essential to the ongoing vitality of the class and are therefore non-negotiable. The Field Recording and Sharing assignment is flexible and ad hoc. However, I strongly advise you not to leave this to the end of term—you'll be too busy with other responsibilities and we don't want a backlog of these presentations to interfere with other seminar activities. I am open to discussions regarding the final due date of your Term Paper, but strongly advise advanced consultation on such matters.

Appeals and Grievances: Instructors are responsible for determining all grades awarded in their courses. Students who have questions about a grade should follow the process outlined in the [Faculty of Arts Grade Appeals Procedure](#). Appeal situations are usually avoidable and the Faculty of Arts advocates early and informal resolution of concerns. Students are therefore encouraged to resolve their concerns first through the Faculty's informal Grade Appeal procedures. This procedure explains that when a student has concerns about a grade, they should first speak with their instructor. If the problem cannot be resolved, the student may then

appeal to the Department Chair. For Fall 2022, the Chair is Professor Cecily Devereux <devereux@ualberta.ca>; for Winter/Spring 2023, the Chair is Professor Eddy Kent <chairefs@ualberta.ca>. In the event that informal resolution is not reached, the [Faculty of Arts Grade Appeals Procedure](#) sets out the Faculty's regulations.

Student Responsibilities:

Academic Integrity: The University of Alberta is committed to the highest standards of academic integrity and honesty. Students are expected to be familiar with these standards regarding academic honesty and to uphold the policies of the University in this respect. Students are particularly urged to familiarize themselves with the provisions of the [Code of Student Behaviour](#) and avoid any behaviour that could potentially result in suspicions of cheating, plagiarism, misrepresentation of facts and/or participation in an offence. Academic dishonesty is a serious offence and can result in suspension or expulsion from the University.

All students should consult [the Academic Integrity website](#). If you have any questions, ask your instructor.

An instructor or coordinator who is convinced that a student has handed in work that he or she could not possibly reproduce without outside assistance is obliged, out of consideration of fairness to other students, to report the case to the Associate Dean of the Faculty. See the [Academic Discipline Process](#).

Students involved in language courses and translation courses should be aware that the use of on-line translation tools to complete assignments constitutes a form of cheating as the student's own understanding and work is therefore not reflected. Also, students in language courses should be aware that, while seeking the advice of native or expert speakers is often helpful, excessive editorial and creative help in assignments is considered a form of cheating that violates the Code of Student Behaviour.

Recording of Lectures: Audio or video recording, digital or otherwise, of lectures, labs, seminars or any other teaching environment by students is allowed only with the prior written consent of the instructor or as a part of an approved accommodation plan. Student or instructor content, digital or otherwise, created and/or used within the context of the course is to be used solely for personal study, and is not to be used or distributed for any other purpose without prior written consent from the content author(s).

Disclaimer: Any typographical errors in this syllabus are subject to change and will be announced in class and posted on eClass. The date of the final examination is set by the Registrar and takes precedence over the final examination date reported in this syllabus.

Student Resources:

The best all-purpose website for student services is: <https://www.ualberta.ca/current-students>.

Accessibility Resources: (1 – 80 SUB)

The University of Alberta is committed to creating work and learning communities that inspire and enable all people to reach their full potential. Accessibility Resources promotes an accessible, inclusive, and universally designed environment. For general information to register for services visit the [Academic Accommodations](#) webpage.

The Academic Success Centre: (1-80 SUB)

[The Academic Success Centre](#) offers a variety of workshops on effective study and exam strategies. There are in-person and online sessions available for a modest fee.

The Centre for Writers: (1-42 Assiniboia Hall)

The [Centre for Writers](#) offers free one-on-one writing support to students, faculty, and staff. Students can request consultation for a writing project at any stage of development. Instructors can request class visits and presentations.

Health and Wellness Support: There are many health and community services available to current students. For more information visit the [Health and Wellness Support](#) webpage.

Office of the Student Ombuds:

The [Office of the Student Ombuds](#) offers confidential interviews, advice and support to students facing academic, discipline, interpersonal and financial difficulties.

Learning and working environment:

The Faculty of Arts is committed to ensuring that all students, faculty and staff are able to work and study in an environment that is safe and free from discrimination and harassment. It does not tolerate behaviour that undermines that environment.

It is the policy of the University of Alberta that sexual violence committed by any member of the University community is prohibited and constitutes misconduct. Resources and more information can be found at <https://www.ualberta.ca/campus-life/sexual-violence>

Policy about course outlines can be found in the [Evaluation Procedures and Grading System](#) section of the University Calendar.